

6. LETTER TO THE EDITOR

A letter to the editor is a formal letter written to a newspaper. Most letters are now sent by email.

Letter to the Editor

Last week I took my teenage grandson to see a performance by the Shake and Stir Theatre Company entitled *I Crave My Space and other Cyber Adventures*. My grandson loved the performance which was very modern and full of action and technical effects.

I found it rather disturbing, not because of the modern music and technology, but because of the message it conveyed about the Internet. This play is a warning to teenagers and their parents about becoming addicted to cyberspace and losing the real meaning of life. I must say that it convinced me.

There were only two actors playing multiple roles, but they showed various forms of cyber addiction. Brian was a games addict who fell in love with his avatar after playing World of War Craft for fifty seven hours. Chelsea spent her life on MySpace, trying to become the most popular girl in 'space', and poor little Dominique believed everything she read on Wikipedia, including that the pyramids were built by aliens. Both of these girls were involved in vicious cyber bullying which is probably the biggest concern of all where the internet is concerned.

When television came to Australia in 1956, our parents were worried about its effect on society. Now it seems that the Internet is replacing television as a source of violence and creating another world that blurs fantasy from reality. What do other readers think?

Granny Grey (*name withheld*)
Brisbane

ACTIVITY:

Read the letter again carefully. List the rules of the genre that are evident in it. Are there any significant omissions?

ACTIVITY:

Read the letter below on the left and check to see how many of the rules in the right hand column have been observed in the letter.

How to write a letter to the editor

- Its purpose is to express an opinion on an issue.
- The introduction outlines the topic and the writer's opinion.
- The body develops the argument logically, point by point, including rebuttal.
- Topic sentences provide clear signposts.
- The conclusion restates opinion, or is a call to action or solution.
- The language is formal and correct, but also persuasive
- The letter may provide examples or statistics.
- Use of first person is acceptable.
- Second person (You) or first person plural (We) may be used as a form of persuasion.
- Hypothetical questions are also persuasive devices.

ACTIVITY:

- a. Write a letter of reply to Granny Grey, defending the Internet, from a teenager's point of view.
- b. Then, collect letters to the editor from your local newspaper. Discuss the issues presented with your classmates.
- c. Find a letter to the editor with which you disagree. Write a new letter to the editor outlining your point of view. This could be a paired or group assignment. Choose the best letters written by class members to email to the newspaper and see if they are published.